

D

Psychology of the Client Conversation

Understanding what the client actually needs. The psychology behind every successful Create The Edge engagement.

D.1 Why Psychology Matters	D.2 Rational vs. Emotional	D.3 The Four Lenses
D.4 Listening for the Unspoken	D.5 Building Trust	D.6 Price Resistance
D.7 Handling Objections	D.8 Reading the Room	D.9 Communication Style
D.10 The Advocate Role	D.11 When to Push Back	D.12 Follow-Up Psychology

WATCH AND LISTEN

Section Briefings

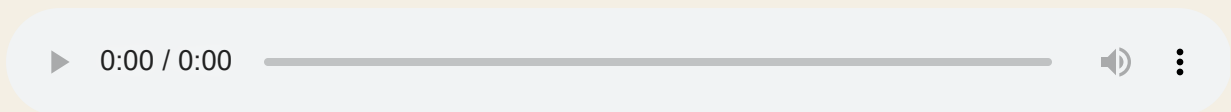
Watch the video, listen to the podcast, then read the module. The psychology of the client conversation in three formats.

VIDEO · THE ARCHITECTURE OF LISTENING



Understanding what the client actually needs through active listening and psychological frameworks.

AUDIO · WIN BIDS WITH MADE, PAID, LOVED



The emotional drivers behind every institutional buying decision, narrated.

MODULE D · PSYCHOLOGY INFOGRAPHIC



Section D Psychology Infographic

 Section D Mind Map

MODULE D • FOUNDATIONS

D.1 • WHY PSYCHOLOGY MATTERS

Why Psychology Matters

*Every client conversation at **Create The Edge** is a psychological event before it is a sales event. This module teaches you to hear what the client is not saying, respond to both emotional and rational needs, and position **Create The Edge** as the trusted advocate every high-stakes project requires.*

Most people assume that professional services are won on credentials, price, and capability. In reality, they are won on trust, perceived understanding, and the client's confidence that you have genuinely heard them. **Create The Edge** has six decades of project experience. That expertise is not enough on its own. What separates a firm that consistently wins from one that consistently writes good proposals and loses is the ability to connect to what the client actually cares about at a human level.

Psychology in the context of a client conversation does not mean manipulation. It means developing genuine curiosity about the person across the table, asking the questions that unlock real understanding, and structuring your response in a way that speaks to both what the client needs technically and what they need emotionally. A client who feels heard signs a proposal faster than a client who is impressed.

” AUTHORITY IN PRACTICE

"The sale is made when the customer is thinking, not when you are talking. Listen first, ask questions, listen again, pull that information out, then present opportunities for them to answer. Guide them. The written proposal then captures what you understood. That is the sequence."

· Marketing Director

FIGURE D.1.1 • THE LISTENING STANDARD AT CREATE THE EDGE**40%****2-3X****4****1**

MAX CONSULTANT
TALK TIME ON A
DISCOVERY CALL

CLIENT RESPONSE
LENGTH VS.
QUESTION LENGTH

PSYCHOLOGICAL
LENSES APPLIED ON
EVERY PROJECT

OPPORTUNITY TO
MAKE A FIRST
PROPOSAL
IMPRESSION

The listening sequence is not passive. It moves through four stages: listen first without agenda, ask questions that dig one level deeper, listen again to what the answers reveal about what is unsaid, and then present the opportunity for the client to confirm or correct your understanding.

Understanding the psychology of the client conversation feeds directly into proposal construction. The first paragraph of every **Create The Edge** proposal exists to prove that you were listening. The questions you ask in the discovery call become the sentences in the proposal's opening paragraph. The emotional driver you identify becomes the tone. The critical event you confirm becomes the urgency.

RULE OF THE HOUSE

The client is not the technical expert. That is why they are coming to you. Never mistake a client's confidence in their own industry for expertise in foodservice or laundry design. They need your knowledge. Deliver it with authority, not with apology. And never deliver it before you have listened long enough to know which part of your knowledge applies.

MODULE D · DECISION FRAMEWORK

D.2 · RATIONAL VS. EMOTIONAL DECISION FRAMEWORK

Rational vs. Emotional Decision Framework

Every buying decision has two components: an emotional driver and a rational justification. The emotional driver is why the person actually wants to make the decision. The rational justification is what they tell their boss, their board, or their budget committee to defend a decision they have already emotionally committed to.

Clients do not make purchase decisions the way they describe making them. The emotional decision typically happens first, often in the first conversation or even the first paragraph of a proposal, and the rational evaluation process provides the justification for

what they have already decided emotionally. Your job is to win the emotional decision first and then arm the client with rational ammunition to defend it internally.

FIGURE D.2.1 • THE THREE EMOTIONAL DRIVERS: MADE, PAID, LOVED

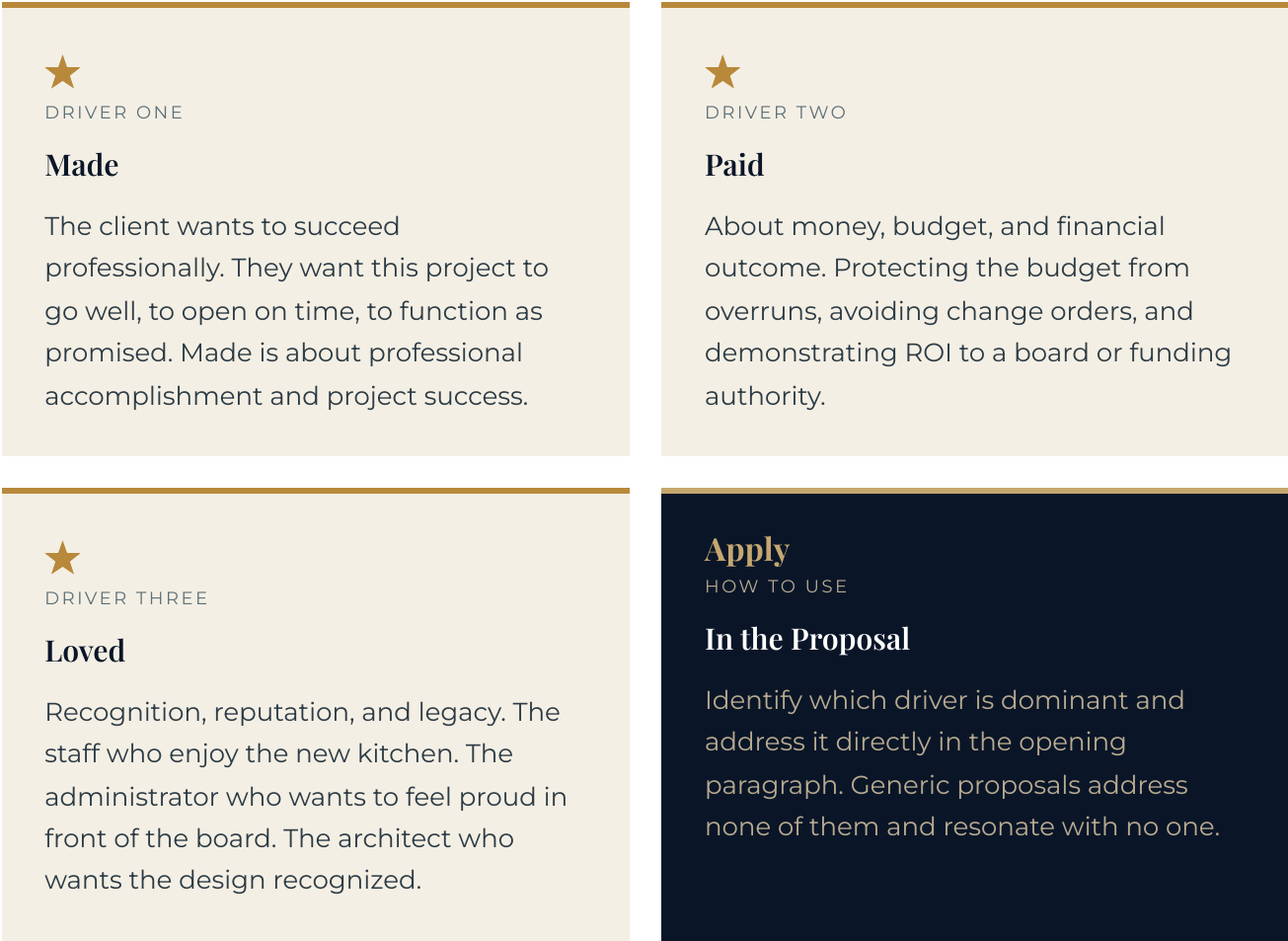


FIGURE D.2.2 • CHAMPION VS. CHECK-SIGNER COMMUNICATION STRATEGY

AUDIENCE	PRIMARY MOTIVATION	WHAT THEY WANT TO HEAR	WHERE IN THE PROPOSAL
Champion (user/operator)	Emotional: Made, Paid, Loved	This project will solve what frustrates you and make you successful	Opening paragraph: context and problem statement
Check-Signer (owner/budget authority)	Rational: ROI, risk, timeline	This is a sound investment with a defensible scope and measurable outcomes	Fee section, phase deliverables, independence statement

✓ BEST PRACTICE

Identify which of the three emotional drivers is dominant for the person you are speaking with and address it directly in the opening paragraph. A proposal written for "Made" sounds different from one written for "Loved." Both are correct. Generic proposals address none of them.

MODULE D · DECISION FRAMEWORK

D.3 · THE FOUR LENSES

The Four Lenses: Impact, Critical Event, Emotional, Rational

Before writing a single word of a proposal, you must have clear answers to four categories of questions. These four lenses give you the complete picture of what the client actually needs, when they need it, why it matters to them personally, and how they will measure success.

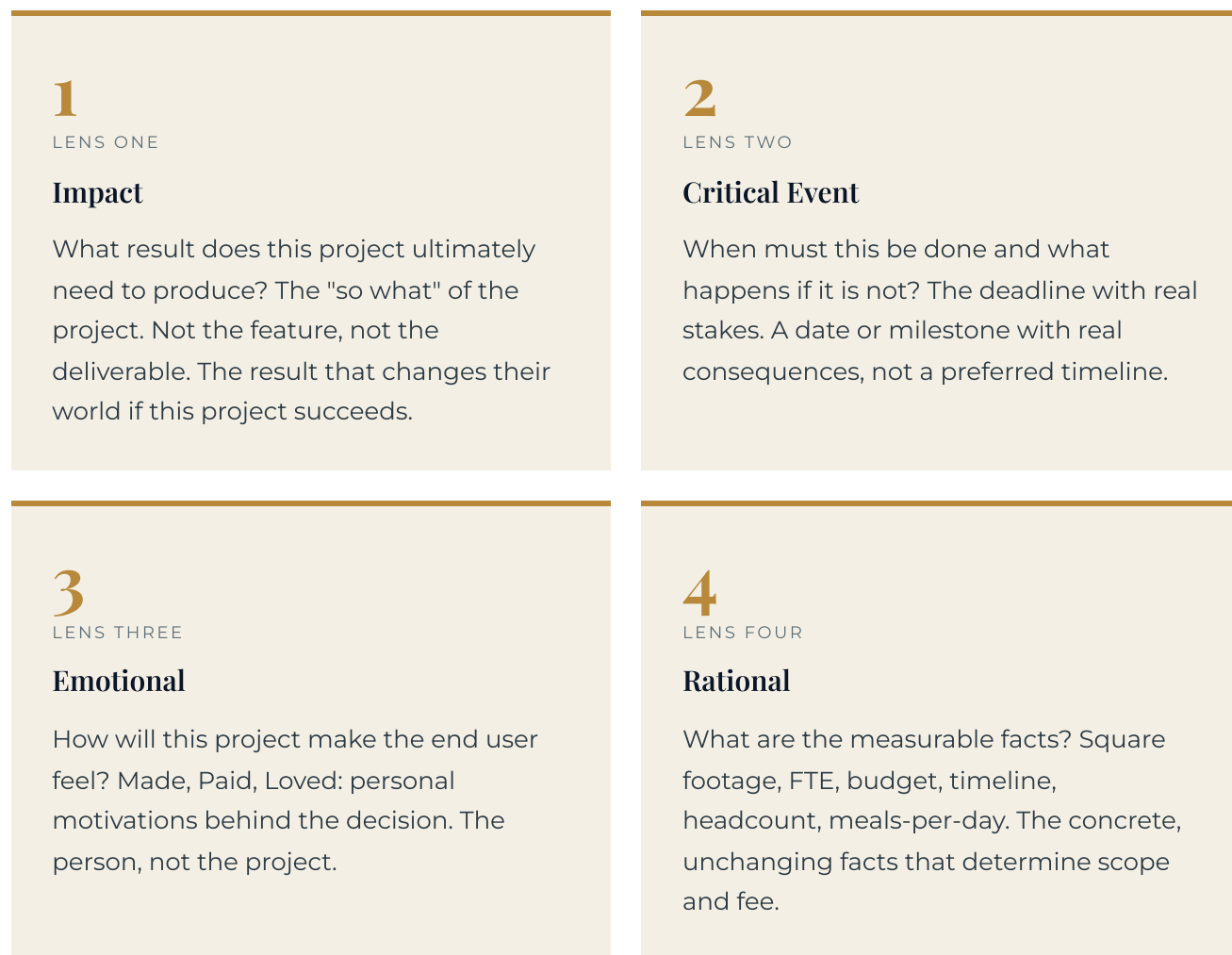


FIGURE D.3.2 • FOUR LENSES: QUESTIONS TO ASK AND WHAT TO DOCUMENT

LENS	KEY QUESTION	FOLLOW-UP	WHAT YOU DOCUMENT
Impact	What needs to be different when this project is done?	How will you know it succeeded?	The operational result the project must produce
Critical Event	When does this need to be complete?	What happens if it is not done by that date?	The date and the consequence of missing it
Emotional	How will a successful outcome affect you and your team?	Is there something you are trying to avoid?	The personal driver: made, paid, or loved
Rational	What are the physical dimensions and headcounts?	What is the approved budget range?	SF, FTE, meals/day, budget, timeline

Question 1: "When does this project need to be complete?" (Client answers readily.)

Question 2: "What happens if it is not complete by that date?" (This is the one that matters. Document this answer specifically.) The answer to Question 2 becomes the urgency that drives proposal priority and the schedule framing in the scope section.

MODULE D · DISCOVERY SKILLS

D.4 · LISTENING FOR THE UNSPOKEN

Listening for What the Client Is Not Saying

The most valuable information in a client conversation is rarely stated directly. Clients hesitate to admit uncertainty, reveal budget constraints, acknowledge internal conflict, or express doubt. They use professional language that softens the real situation. Your job is to hear what is underneath that language.

D.4.1 · The Ishikawa Framework: Five Layers Deep

The Ishikawa framework teaches you to ask "why" five times before you accept the stated need as the real need. A client who says they need a new kitchen is at layer one. The real need may be four or five layers deeper: they need to reduce staff turnover caused by an unsafe work environment, which is ultimately about protecting the director's employment by improving the facility's inspection record. Knowing the fifth-layer need produces a more powerful proposal than knowing only the first.

FIGURE D.4.1 · THE FIVE WHYS: FROM SURFACE NEED TO ROOT CAUSE

1

Surface Need

"I need to buy tissues." / "We need a new kitchen." The stated request that begins the conversation.

2

Symptom

"I have a runny nose." / "Our equipment is failing and staff are overwhelmed." The visible problem.

3

Condition

"I am getting sick." / "We had three health violations last year." The underlying condition producing the symptom.

4

Concern

"I might spread germs to others." / "This is becoming a liability issue." What the person is actually worried about.

5

Root Motivation

"I want to protect my family." / "I need to protect my employment by securing a flawless inspection record." The real driver.

FIGURE D.4.2 · LANGUAGE SIGNALS AND WHAT THEY REVEAL

WHAT THE CLIENT SAYS	WHAT IT OFTEN MEANS	YOUR RESPONSE STRATEGY
"We just need something simple."	Budget anxiety or past experience with scope creep	Confirm scope carefully before discussing fee; show how Create The Edge phases work
"We've had problems with consultants before."	Trust is the primary obstacle	Ask what went wrong; listen; address the specific concern directly
"We think our budget is around..."	Budget not yet formally approved internally	Help them articulate the business case for their check-signer
"Ideally we'd like to be done by..."	Timeline is not firm; no critical event confirmed yet	Ask what happens if the ideal date is not met; find the real deadline
"Our architect said we should call you."	Inbound referral; relationship matters	Acknowledge the relationship; move quickly to scope confirmation
"We got three other quotes."	Fee is being compared; value differentiation is required	Do not compete on price; reinforce Create The Edge's independence and precision

Never finish a discovery call with uncertainty about: who makes the final decision, what the critical event is, and what budget range the client is working within. If any of these three are unclear, ask directly before closing: "Just so I can write a proposal that works for your situation, can you help me understand..."

MODULE D · DISCOVERY SKILLS

D.5 · BUILDING TRUST

Building Trust Before Building Anything

Trust is not built through credentials. It is built through behavior. Clients assess whether they trust a consulting firm within the first conversation based on whether the firm listens more than it talks, asks questions that prove genuine understanding, and responds with precision rather than volume.

The most common trust obstacle **Create The Edge** faces in new client relationships is the assumption that the firm earns commissions from equipment sales. This misconception must be addressed early, specifically, and confidently: "We are completely fee-only. We don't sell equipment and we receive no commissions from manufacturers or dealers. Our only financial relationship is with you. That is why we can recommend whatever is best for your project and your budget without any conflict of interest."

” ON INDEPENDENCE AND TRUST

"Our biggest differentiation is this: we are advocates. We don't sell equipment and a dealer does. When a client doesn't fully understand that distinction, the end product gets discounted. They go, 'yeah, it's a great kitchen, but why go with a consultant again?' The independence statement is not a legal disclaimer. It is the answer to that question before it is asked."

· Marketing Director

FIGURE D.5.1 · FIVE TRUST-BUILDING BEHAVIORS

1. **Responsive Execution:** Calls returned within 24 to 36 hours. Emails acknowledged same day. Reliability in communication signals reliability in project execution. Clients equate the two.

2. **Concise and Factual:** Direct, data-grounded communication without filler or hedging. When you do not know an answer, say you will find out by a specific time and then do it.
3. **Confident Authority:** Precision, not volume. The consultant who speaks less but says more accurate things earns trust faster. Know the numbers, know the codes, know the sector.
4. **Demonstrate Before Asking:** Never ask for the project before you have demonstrated value. Give something first: an insight, a relevant observation, a question that proves you have done your homework.
5. **Keep Every Commitment:** If you say you will send the proposal by Thursday, it goes Thursday. Trust is destroyed more quickly by missed commitments than it is built by capabilities.

MODULE D · DISCOVERY SKILLS

D.6 · PSYCHOLOGY OF PRICE RESISTANCE

Psychology of Price Resistance

Price resistance is not primarily about money. It is about perceived value, perceived risk, and perceived alternatives. Diagnosing which concern is present determines how you respond.

1

ROOT ONE

Value Gap

Client does not yet connect the fee to a concrete outcome. Cure: Add specific impact statements that tie the fee to what the project will actually produce.

2

ROOT TWO

Scope Confusion

Client does not understand what the fee actually includes. Cure: Walk through each phase and its specific deliverable clearly and completely.

3

ROOT THREE

False Comparison

Comparing **Create The Edge** to a dealer-affiliated or less qualified firm. Cure: Clarify what independence means and why it matters for their project.

4

ROOT FOUR

Budget Pressure

Internal constraint unrelated to the specific fee amount. Cure: Explore phasing or scope adjustment options that fit within their approved ceiling.

When a client expresses fee concern, the first response is never a reduction. The first response is a question: **"Help me understand what you are comparing it to."** This single question reveals which of the four root causes is present. You cannot solve a problem you have not yet diagnosed. The worst response to price resistance is to immediately offer a discount.

⚠ WATCH OUT

Never respond to price resistance by apologizing for the fee. A fee at **Create The Edge** is calculated from labor hours and sector-standard equipment benchmarks. It is not a guess and it is not inflated. When you apologize for or immediately retreat from a fee, you communicate that it was not based on sound methodology. Keep the fee. Explain the methodology. Explore legitimate alternatives if needed.

” ON PRICE AND CARING

"This is an expensive project, yes. And I want it to be perfect. Perfect for your budget and for what you need. This is not about nickel and diming. This is about creating the right outcome. That is what the fee pays for."

· Marketing Director

MODULE D · DISCOVERY SKILLS

D.7 · HANDLING OBJECTIONS

Handling Objections Without Losing Authority

An objection is information. It tells you what the client has not yet understood, what concern they have not yet resolved, or what they need before they can say yes. The goal is to receive the objection with composure, understand it fully, and respond with precision.

FIGURE D.7.1 • THE FOUR-STEP OBJECTION RESPONSE

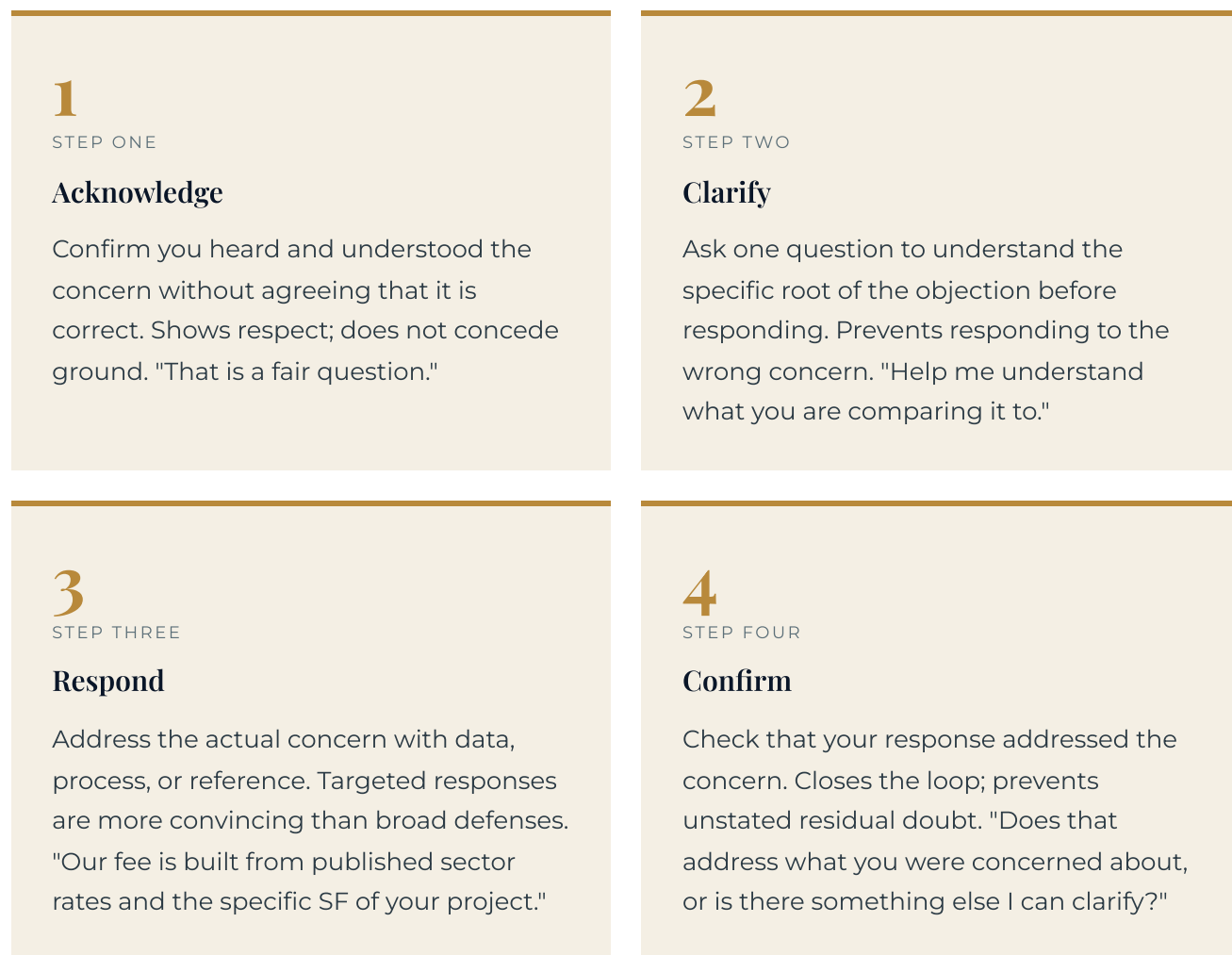


FIGURE D.7.2 • COMMON OBJECTIONS AND RESPONSE STRATEGIES

OBJECTION	ROOT CONCERN	EFFECTIVE RESPONSE
"We can get drawings from our equipment dealer for free."	False comparison; does not understand independent consulting value	Explain the conflict of interest in dealer-produced drawings. Specifications reflect what they sell, not what you need.
"Your timeline seems too long."	Does not understand the phase deliverables or work involved	Walk through each phase and its specific deliverable. Show how timeline connects to critical event milestones.
"We have done this before without a consultant."	Questioning the necessity of the service	Ask what happened: change orders, health department flags, equipment problems post-opening? Address the specific experience.
"Can you do it for less?"	Budget constraint or fee not yet connected to value	Diagnose first. If budget constraint: explore phasing. If value disconnect: walk through what the fee includes and the cost of errors.

✓ BEST PRACTICE

The consultant who says "that is a great question, let me think about that for a moment" maintains far more authority than the one who blurts an immediate defensive response. Composure is authority. You do not have to answer every objection instantly. You have to answer it accurately.

MODULE D · COMMUNICATION

D.8 · READING THE ROOM

Reading the Room

Reading the room is the skill of adjusting your communication, your pacing, and your content in real time based on what you observe in the client's responses and conversational signals. When you read the room accurately, the conversation feels natural and productive to the client.

FIGURE D.8.1 · CLIENT SIGNALS AND WHAT THEY MEAN

SIGNAL	WHAT IT TYPICALLY INDICATES	ADJUSTMENT TO MAKE
Short answers, monosyllabic responses	Disengagement or discomfort with the current topic	Ask a more open-ended question; shift to a topic closer to their stated concern
Long, detailed answers without prompting	Strong engagement; the topic matters to them	Listen without interrupting; this is high-value information
Repeated return to the same topic	This is the real concern; it is not resolved	Stop and address it directly: "I notice we keep coming back to this. Let me make sure I understand it fully."
Leaning forward, asking follow-up questions	Active interest; increasing trust	Go deeper on the topic; this is your best material for proposal grounding
Silence after a question	Processing, uncertainty, or something unspoken	Do not fill silence immediately; give the client space to speak into it

In meetings with multiple stakeholders, each person in the room has different motivations and different concerns. Watch for who nods, who takes notes, and who asks clarifying questions. These are your engaged stakeholders. Watch also for who goes quiet or defers to others. These are often the decision influencers who have not yet been convinced. Confirm before leaving that all present had an opportunity to raise their specific questions.

MODULE D · COMMUNICATION

D.9 · COMMUNICATION STYLE ADAPTATION

Communication Style Adaptation

Different clients require different communication styles. Reading which client is in front of you and adjusting your communication style accordingly is a core professional skill at [Create The Edge](#).

1

PROFILE ONE

The Expert Client

Has domain knowledge. Knows the terminology. Has worked with consultants before. Wants precision, efficiency, and depth. Skip the basics. Use technical language correctly. Waste of their time signals disrespect.

2

PROFILE TWO

The First-Timer

Has never hired a foodservice or laundry design consultant. Does not know what the phases produce or why a fee is structured the way it is. Needs context before content. Patience here builds lasting trust.

3

PROFILE THREE

The Institutional Buyer

Operates through committees, procurement processes, and approval chains. Values compliance, documentation, and process. Less interested in creative framing; more interested in clear scope, timeline, and defensible fees.

Adapt

HOW TO APPLY

Real Time

You will not always know in advance which profile fits. The first two minutes of the conversation usually tell you. Pitching at the wrong level in either direction costs projects.

■ RULE OF THE HOUSE

Match the client's language. If they call the facility a "kitchen," you call it a kitchen in conversation, even if you write "foodservice facility" in the proposal. Using jargon they do not use creates distance. Meeting them in their language creates connection. The technical precision lives in the written document.

D.10 · THE ADVOCATE ROLE

The Advocate Role

Create The Edge is not a vendor. It is an independent consultant whose sole financial relationship is with the client and whose sole obligation is to the client's project outcomes. This is the advocate role: standing in the client's corner with no competing financial interest.

Vendor-neutral means that **Create The Edge**'s specifications are written to performance requirements, not to product brand names. When a product brand is specified, it is because it meets the operational requirements better than the alternatives, not because there is a financial relationship with the manufacturer. Every equipment recommendation is defensible by its technical merit.

When clients ask about equipment options, **Create The Edge** presents a good-better-best framework that allows the client to make an informed decision based on budget, operational priorities, and tolerance for lifecycle maintenance costs. One critical message: every piece of equipment will eventually break. The question is not whether it breaks but how quickly and easily it is repaired when it does. The recommendation always includes a reliability and service response note, not just a price comparison.

” ON THE ADVOCATE ROLE

"Our biggest thing is we are advocates. We don't sell equipment and a dealer does. The customer still doesn't fully trust us yet in many cases, and if we don't pay attention to that, the end result is they go, 'yeah, it's a great kitchen, but why go with a consultant again?' The answer to that question is this: because we were on your side the whole time."

· Marketing Director

When you deliver the proposal, draw the client's attention to the independence statement specifically. Do not assume they will read it carefully or understand its significance without context. Explain what it means and why it matters for their project: their specification will reflect what they need, not what someone else profits from.

MODULE D · COMMUNICATION

D.11 · WHEN TO PUSH BACK

When and How to Push Back

Advocacy sometimes requires disagreement. A client who insists on a kitchen layout that will not function operationally, a timeline that is not achievable, or a scope reduction that will create compliance risk needs to hear the truth, delivered with respect and documented in writing.

Pushing back does not mean refusing to accommodate client preferences. It means making sure the client understands the professional implications of a decision before confirming that it is their decision to make. **Create The Edge** does not override client decisions. It ensures they are informed ones.

FIGURE D.11.1 · SITUATIONS REQUIRING PUSHBACK AND HOW TO FRAME IT

SITUATION	WHY PUSHBACK IS NECESSARY	HOW TO FRAME IT
Client wants to eliminate the hand sink requirement	Health code compliance; this is not optional	"I understand the space concern. I have to be direct with you: this item is required by code. Removing it is not an option we can design around without creating an inspection failure."
Client insists on a 6-week design timeline for a 12-week scope	Unrealistic timeline creates downstream liability	"I want to make sure we set this up for success. That timeline does not allow for the review cycles your project requires. Let me show you what is achievable and where we can compress."

SITUATION	WHY PUSHBACK IS NECESSARY	HOW TO FRAME IT
Client wants to remove the CA phase to save fee	Construction Administration catches field errors; removing it shifts risk to client	"That is your choice and I respect it. I do want to make sure you understand what CA covers and what happens in the field without that oversight. Would you like me to walk through that before you decide?"
Client requests vendor-specific specification without justification	Compromises independence and may violate procurement rules	"I understand the preference. Our specifications need to be performance-based to protect your procurement process and our professional independence. I can note that product as the basis of design."

✓ **BEST PRACTICE: DOCUMENT THE PUSHBACK**

When a client chooses to proceed contrary to a professional recommendation, the recommendation and the client's decision must be documented. This protects the client from a decision made without full information, and it protects **Create The Edge** from liability. Document in [CRM Software] and in some cases confirm in writing via email: "Per our conversation on [date], you have confirmed that you wish to proceed with [decision], understanding that [implication]. Please confirm this is correct."

MODULE D • COMMUNICATION

D.12 • FOLLOW-UP PSYCHOLOGY

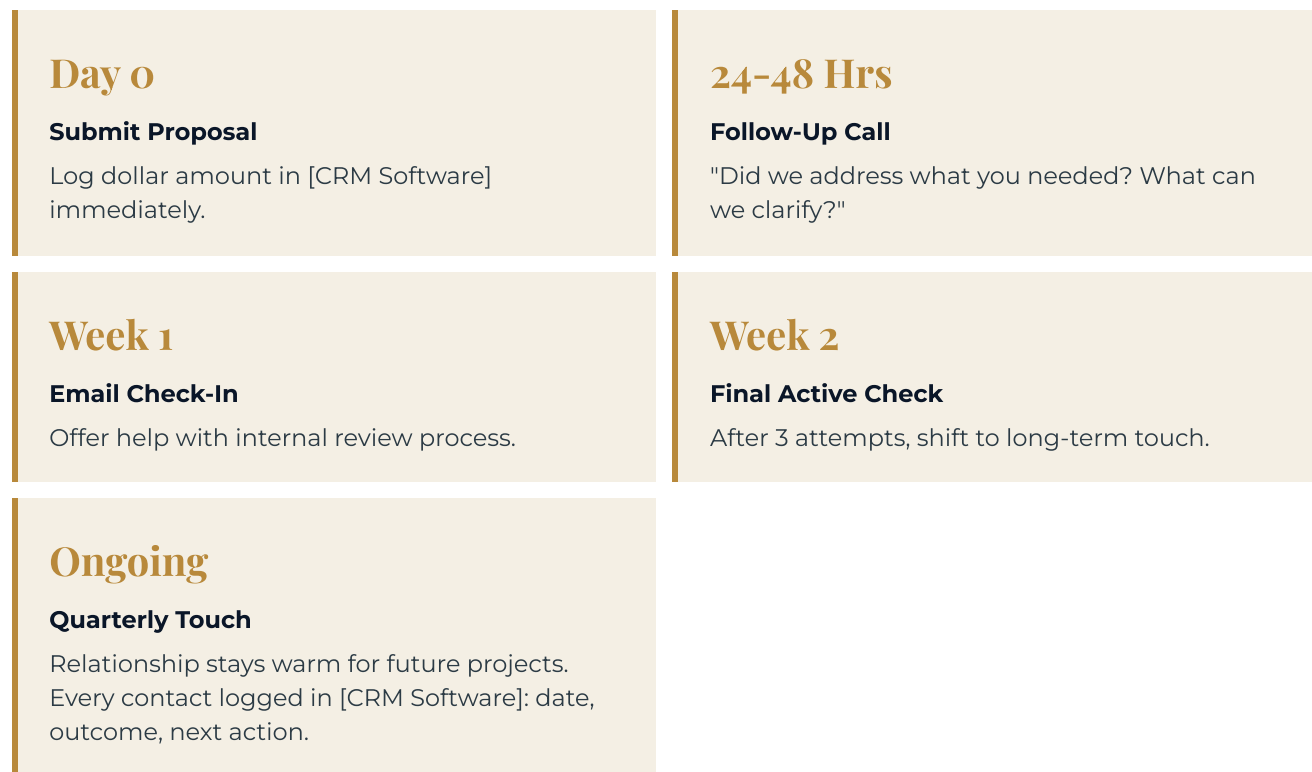
Psychology of Follow-Up

Follow-up is not a sales technique. It is a relationship behavior. The consultant who follows up is communicating something more important than "have you made a decision?" They are communicating: I am thinking about your project. I am organized. I do what I said I would.

Every proposal submission is followed by a 24-to-48-hour follow-up contact. This is Step 7 of the 10-Step Outreach Framework and it is non-negotiable. The purpose of the follow-up call is not to ask whether they received the proposal. It is to ask: "Did we address what

you needed? Is there anything in the proposal you would like me to walk through?" This question opens a conversation that may surface the final objection standing between the client and a yes.

FIGURE D.12.1 • THE FOLLOW-UP TIMELINE



The psychological distinction between follow-up that creates pressure and follow-up that creates relationship is this: pressure asks what the client has decided. Relationship asks what the client needs. Follow-up calls at **Create The Edge** begin with an offer, not a request. "I wanted to make sure we had addressed everything you needed." Not: "We were hoping to get your decision."

” ON FOLLOW-UP AS RELATIONSHIP

"Follow-up is about creating the relationship, not about closing the sale. When you follow up to serve the client's needs, you are demonstrating the same qualities you will demonstrate throughout the project. A client who sees that in you before the contract is signed is far more likely to sign it."

· Marketing Director

RULE OF THE HOUSE

Every proposal submission gets a 24-to-48-hour follow-up call. Every call gets logged in [CRM Software] with the outcome noted. If the client is not reachable by phone, a follow-up email is sent with the same two questions: Did we address what you needed? What can we clarify? No proposal sits without a follow-up attempt.

MODULE D · ASSESSMENT

✓ COMPREHENSIVE TEST

Psychology of the Client Conversation: Assessment

15 questions. Do not check answers until you have completed the entire test. The Answer Legend follows on a separate page.

D.1

According to the **Create The Edge** listening standard, what percentage of talk time should the consultant aim for in a discovery call?

- ☐ A No more than 60% of the conversation
- ☐ B No more than 40% of the conversation
- ☐ C No more than 50% of the conversation
- ☐ D No more than 25% of the conversation

D.2

In the Rational vs. Emotional Decision Framework, which of the following best describes the role of rational data in a buying decision?

- ☐ A Rational data drives the initial decision and emotional factors confirm it afterward
- ☐ B Rational and emotional data carry equal weight at every stage of the decision process
- ☐ C Rational data provides the justification for a decision that was already made emotionally
- ☐ D Rational data is used only by financial officers and has no relevance to operational stakeholders

D.3

The "Made, Paid, Loved" framework describes which of the following?

- ☐ A The three phases of a **Create The Edge** proposal: narrative, scope, and fee
- ☐ B The three types of clients: inbound, outbound, and referral
- ☐ C The three rational metrics used in equipment budget calculations
- ☐ D The three emotional drivers that motivate professional buying decisions

D.4

What are the two parts of a Critical Event that a **Create The Edge** consultant must identify and document?

- ☐ A The project budget and the number of stakeholders involved in the decision
- ☐ B The specific date of the event and what happens if that date is not met
- ☐ C The architect's preferred timeline and the owner's preferred timeline
- ☐ D The project kickoff date and the final punch list date

D.5

Which of the following best describes the purpose of the Ishikawa (Five Whys) framework in a client conversation?

- ☐ A To structure the proposal's five core phases in the correct sequence
- ☐ B To move from the surface request to the deeper root need driving the client's decision
- ☐ C To identify the five rational metrics required for fee calculation
- ☐ D To document the client's five most important technical requirements

D.6

A client says, "We can get drawings from our equipment dealer for free." What is the most appropriate first response?

- ☐ A Acknowledge the comment and explain how dealer-produced drawings differ from independent consulting specifications
- ☐ B Offer to reduce the **Create The Edge** fee to match what the dealer would charge
- ☐ C Ask which dealer they are considering so you can explain the technical differences
- ☐ D Agree that the dealer's drawings may be sufficient for their project needs

D.7

According to the four-step objection response framework, what is the second step after acknowledging an objection?

- A** Clarify: ask one question to understand the specific root of the objection before responding
- B** Respond: immediately provide the data or explanation that addresses the concern
- C** Confirm: ask whether your response addressed what the client was concerned about
- D** Document: log the objection in [CRM Software] before continuing the conversation

D.8

What does it typically indicate when a client gives short, monosyllabic responses during a discovery conversation?

- A** Strong engagement with the topic; the client prefers concise communication
- B** Disengagement or discomfort with the current topic; adjustment is needed
- C** Budget anxiety; the client is hesitant to reveal their financial situation
- D** A signal that the client wants to end the conversation and review the proposal later

D.9

What is the most important first question to ask when a client says "your fee seems high"?

- A** "Would you like us to reduce the scope to bring the fee in line with your budget?"
- B** "Help me understand what you are comparing it to."
- C** "What budget range were you expecting for this type of project?"
- D** "Can you tell me which phase of the scope you feel is overpriced?"

D.10

Which of the following is the most accurate description of **Create The Edge**'s position as an independent consultant?

- A Create The Edge** specifies preferred manufacturer brands based on long-standing vendor relationships
- B Create The Edge** receives no commissions from manufacturers or dealers and writes specifications based solely on the client's operational needs
- C Create The Edge** coordinates equipment purchases directly with dealers on behalf of the client to secure preferred pricing
- D Create The Edge** maintains preferred vendor lists that help clients source equipment faster and at lower cost

D.11

When should a **Create The Edge** consultant document a client's decision to proceed against a professional recommendation?

- A** Only when the decision creates a legal liability risk for **Create The Edge** specifically
- B** Only when the client has been informed three times and still refuses to change course
- C** Whenever a client chooses to proceed contrary to a professional recommendation, as standard practice
- D** Only when the decision involves a compliance issue; other decisions do not require documentation

D.12

What is the standard follow-up timeline after a proposal is submitted at **Create The Edge**?

- A** One week after submission, to allow the client time to review thoroughly
- B** Same day, to confirm receipt and address any immediate questions
- C** 24 to 48 hours after submission, to ask whether the proposal addressed what the client needed
- D** Only after the client contacts **Create The Edge** with questions; proactive follow-up is considered pressure

D.13

When a client says "we think our budget is around..." what does this phrasing most likely indicate?

- ☐ A The client has a firm budget but is testing whether the consultant will propose under it
- ☐ B The budget has not yet been formally approved internally; advocacy with the check-signer may still be needed
- ☐ C The client expects the consultant to propose at exactly that figure
- ☐ D The client is comparing multiple proposals and using a common benchmark

D.14

For an "Institutional Buyer" client profile, which communication approach is most effective?

- ☐ A Emotional framing focused on personal success and project recognition
- ☐ B Process-oriented language emphasizing compliance, documentation, and clear deliverables
- ☐ C Simplified explanations that assume no prior experience with consulting services
- ☐ D Technical deep-dives using specialized equipment terminology to establish credibility

D.15

When following up with a client whose proposal decision is pending due to a committee approval process, which approach best reflects **Create The Edge's** follow-up psychology?

- ☐ A "We need a decision by Friday to hold your project timeline."
- ☐ B "Is there anything I can provide that would help your internal review process?"
- ☐ C "We have other projects starting soon and need to know if we should hold capacity."
- ☐ D Do not follow up at all during committee review; wait for the client to reach out.

D.1

Correct: B · No more than 40% of the conversation

The Create The Edge listening standard sets 40% as the maximum talk time on a discovery call. The purpose is to create space for the client to reveal the information needed to write an accurate proposal. See D.1.

D.2

Correct: C · Rational data provides the justification for a decision already made emotionally

Emotional decisions happen first; rational data justifies them afterward. Win the emotional decision first, then arm the client with rational ammunition to defend it internally. See D.2.

D.3

Correct: D · The three emotional drivers that motivate professional buying decisions

Made = professional success; Paid = financial outcome; Loved = recognition and reputation. Identifying the dominant driver shapes how you frame the proposal's opening paragraph. See D.2.

D.4

Correct: B · The specific date and what happens if that date is not met

A critical event has two essential components: the date itself and the consequence of missing it. The consequence question is the one most often skipped, and it is the one that reveals real urgency. See D.3.

D.5

Correct: B · To move from the surface request to the deeper root need

The Ishikawa framework moves from a stated surface need to the underlying root cause by asking why repeatedly. Knowing the root produces a more resonant proposal. See D.4.

D.6

Correct: A · Acknowledge and explain the structural difference

Acknowledge without conceding ground, then explain that dealer drawings reflect the dealer's inventory, not independent performance specifications. Reducing the fee without addressing this rewards misunderstanding. See D.5.

D.7

Correct: A · Clarify: ask one question to understand the root of the objection

The four steps are: Acknowledge, Clarify, Respond, Confirm. Clarification comes before response because responding to the wrong concern is ineffective and can introduce new problems. See D.7.

D.8

Correct: B · Disengagement or discomfort with the current topic

Short, minimal responses typically signal disengagement. When you notice this signal, shift the topic or ask a more open-ended question to re-engage. See D.8.

MODULE D · ASSESSMENT

☑ **ANSWER LEGEND · PART 2 OF 2**

Answers · D.9 through D.15

The remaining answers with reasoning and sub-module cross-references.

D.9

Correct: B · "Help me understand what you are comparing it to."

Diagnosing the root of the objection before responding is the correct approach. This single question reveals which of the four roots is present. Never respond to price resistance without first diagnosing what is actually driving it. See D.6.

D.10

Correct: B · No commissions; specifications based solely on client operational needs

Create The Edge is a fee-only independent consultant with no manufacturer or dealer affiliations. The independence statement in every proposal codifies this position. It is a fundamental differentiator, not a disclaimer. See D.10.

D.11

Correct: C · Whenever a client proceeds contrary to a professional recommendation, as standard practice

Documentation of client decisions against professional advice is standard practice, not a situation-specific response. Documentation protects both the client and the firm. See D.11.

D.12

Correct: C · 24 to 48 hours after submission

The Create The Edge standard is a 24-to-48-hour follow-up after every proposal submission, per Step 7 of the 10-Step Outreach Framework. The follow-up call asks whether the proposal addressed the client's needs, not whether they have made a decision. See D.12.

D.13

Correct: B · The budget has not yet been formally approved internally

Tentative budget language signals that the number is not yet formally approved. The client may benefit from help articulating the business case for their check-signer. See D.4.

D.14

Correct: B · Process-oriented language emphasizing compliance, documentation, and clear deliverables

Institutional buyers operate through committees, procurement processes, and approval chains. They value compliance, documentation, and process clarity above emotional or overly technical framing. See D.9.

D.15

Correct: B · "Is there anything I can provide that would help your internal review process?"

This question serves the client's needs during their review process without applying pressure. Pressure implies urgency the consultant does not control. The correct approach creates relationship, not pressure. See D.12.

MODULE D · STUDY TOOLS

◆ FLASHCARDS · REFERENCE GRID

Fifteen Cards · Front and Back

Fifteen flashcards covering the key frameworks and concepts from Section D.

1 The Listening Standard

No more than 40% consultant talk time on a discovery call. Client responses should be 2-3x longer than questions. Listen, ask, listen again, present opportunity, guide.

(D.1)

2 Emotional vs. Rational Decision

Emotional decisions happen first; rational data justifies them afterward. Win the emotional decision first, then arm the client with rational ammunition to defend it internally.

(D.2)

3 Made, Paid, Loved

Three emotional drivers: Made = professional success; Paid = financial outcome and budget protection; Loved = recognition, reputation,

4 Champion vs. Check-Signer

Champion (user/operator) responds to emotional impact. Check-Signer (owner/budget authority) responds to rational

and legacy. Identify the dominant driver before writing the proposal.

(D.2)

justification. Proposals must address both. Know who is in each role.

(D.2)

5 The Four Lenses

Impact: the result the project must produce. Critical Event: the date and consequence of missing it. Emotional: Made/Paid/Loved. Rational: SF, FTE, budget, timeline.

(D.3)

6 Critical Event: Two Required Questions

1. When does this project need to be complete? 2. What happens if it is not complete by that date? Both must be documented. The second question reveals the real urgency and stakes.

(D.3)

7 Ishikawa / Five Whys

Ask "why" five layers deep to move from the surface request to the root need. A client who needs "a new kitchen" may actually need to protect their employment by improving the inspection record.

(D.4)

8 The Primary Trust Obstacle

"You sell equipment." Address this early and clearly: "We are completely fee-only. We receive no commissions from manufacturers or dealers. Our only financial relationship is with you."

(D.5)

9 Four Roots of Price Resistance

1. Value Gap: fee not connected to outcome. 2. Scope Confusion: client does not understand inclusions. 3. False Comparison: comparing to a dealer. 4. Budget Pressure: internal constraint.

(D.6)

10 Four-Step Objection Response

1. Acknowledge: heard without conceding. 2. Clarify: ask one question to understand root. 3. Respond: address actual concern with precision. 4. Confirm: did that address what you were concerned about?

(D.7)

11 Three Client Communication Profiles

Expert Client: technical language, concise, respect their knowledge. First-Timer: context before content, explain the consulting model. Institutional Buyer: process, compliance, documentation, clear deliverables.

(D.9)

12 The Advocate Role

Create The Edge is fee-only with no manufacturer or dealer commissions. Specifications reflect only the client's operational needs. Recommendations are made based on technical merit alone. This is independent advocacy.

(D.10)

13 Good, Better, Best Framework

Present equipment options across three tiers. Always include reliability and service response data. Every piece of equipment eventually breaks; what matters is how quickly it is repaired. Client chooses; consultant informs.

14 When Pushback Is Required

1. Decision based on incomplete information. 2. Client preference creates compliance risk. 3. Timeline or budget is not achievable. 4. Scope reduction compromises quality. Document all pushback and client responses.

(D.10)

(D.11)

15

Follow-Up: Relationship vs. Pressure

Pressure asks what the client decided.
Relationship asks what the client needs. Follow up within 24-48 hours with: "Did we address what you needed? What can I clarify?" Log every contact in [CRM Software].

(D.12)

MODULE D · STUDY TOOLS

▣ FLASHCARDS · INTERACTIVE

Tap the Card to See the Answer

Fifteen cards, one at a time. Read the front, attempt the back from memory, then tap to check.

TERM · TAP TO REVEAL

The Listening Standard

Tap card to flip · Use arrows to navigate

← PREVIOUS

1 of 15

NEXT →



✂️ PRINTABLE CUT-OUT STUDY CARDS

Print, Cut, Carry

Fifteen cards arranged for printing. Cut along the borders. Keep them on your desk.

The Listening Standard

No more than 40% consultant talk time. Client responses should be 2-3x longer than questions. Listen, ask, listen again, present, guide.

Emotional vs. Rational

Emotional decisions happen first. Rational data justifies them afterward. Win the emotion first; arm the client with rational ammunition to defend internally.

Made, Paid, Loved

Made = professional success. Paid = financial/budget outcome. Loved = recognition and reputation. Identify the dominant driver before writing the proposal.

Champion vs. Check-Signer

Champion: emotional impact. Check-Signer: rational justification, ROI, risk. Proposals must address both. Know who is in each role before submission.

The Four Lenses

Impact, Critical Event, Emotional (Made/Paid/Loved), Rational (SF, FTE, budget). All four must be answered before writing the proposal.

Critical Event: Two Questions

1. When does this project need to be complete?
 2. What happens if it is not done by that date?
- The second question reveals real urgency.

Ishikawa / Five Whys

Ask why five times to move from surface request to root need. Surface: "new kitchen." Root: "protect employment by securing a flawless inspection record."

The Primary Trust Obstacle

"You sell equipment." Address early: "We are fee-only. No manufacturer commissions. Our only financial relationship is with you."

Four Roots of Price Resistance

1. Value Gap.
 2. Scope Confusion.
 3. False Comparison.
 4. Budget Pressure.
- Diagnose which root before responding. Never discount without diagnosing.

Four-Step Objection Response

1. Acknowledge.
 2. Clarify.
 3. Respond.
 4. Confirm.
- Skip none. Respond to the wrong concern and you create new problems.

Three Client Profiles

Expert: technical, concise. First-Timer: context before content. Institutional Buyer: process, compliance, documentation, defensible fees.

The Advocate Role

Fee-only. No manufacturer or dealer commissions. Specifications based solely on client operational needs. Recommendations by technical merit alone.

Good, Better, Best

Present three equipment tiers. Always include reliability and service response data. Client chooses; consultant informs. Never decide for them.

When Pushback Is Required

1. Incomplete information. 2. Compliance risk. 3. Unrealistic timeline/budget. 4. Scope reduction that compromises quality. Document all pushback in [CRM Software].

Follow-Up: Relationship, Not Pressure

24-48 hours: "Did we address what you needed? What can I clarify?" Log every contact: date, outcome, next action. Three attempts, then quarterly touch.

MODULE D · PRESENTATION

FULL SLIDE DECK

The Architecture of Discovery

The complete presentation for this module. Each slide is embedded directly. Scroll through all 15 slides below.



